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HIS HOLINESS POPE LEO XIV
XV · V · MMXXVI

Magnifica *Humanitas*

On Safeguarding the Human Person in the Time of Artificial Intelligence

PROMULGATED

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EXTENT

245 paragraphs · V chapters

TRADITION

Doctrina socialis

INCIPIT · THE OPENING

Humanity stands
before an epochal
choice: to raise a
new *Tower of Babel*,
or to rebuild
together the *walls*
of Jerusalem.

FROM THE OPENING · NN. 1–10

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The Res Novae of Our Time

The new things of our age

I
THE EPOCHAL
CHOICE

Every generation inherits the task of shaping its era; yet ours possesses an unprecedented capacity for both self-destruction and profound dehumanization, borne by the rapid advance of digitalization, artificial intelligence, and robotics. Where Leo XIII confronted the *res novae* of the industrial age, the new things of our day are the digital and artificial-intelligence revolution. Technology is no enemy of humanity — it is a profoundly human reality, bound to our freedom — but its power is now woven into the very fabric of daily life and collective imagination.

4-6
THE PRIVATIZATION
OF POWER

What makes this hour radically new is that the chief authors of this development are private, transnational powers, whose resources and capacities surpass those of many governments. This unprecedented privatization of power makes the new technologies exceptionally difficult to discern, to govern, and to direct toward the common good. We do not face a passing emergency, but a change of era.

7–10

BABEL OR JERUSALEM

Two biblical images set our course. The *Tower of Babel* is the project of self-sufficiency and pride — the homogenization of humanity, dignity sacrificed to efficiency, the pretense of reaching heaven without God. Its modern syndrome is the idolatry of profit and the conceit that a single digital language can translate the mystery of the person into data and performance. The *rebuilding of Jerusalem* is the other path: Nehemiah imposed nothing from above but convened families and assigned them their portion of the wall. So too our age calls for shared responsibility, for synodality, for diversity received as a resource.

Technology is never neutral; it takes on the characteristics of those who devise and finance it.

NN. 9

11–16

FOR THE COMMON GOOD

To build a city upon the common good we must accept the limits and weakness of humanity, refusing to treat them as “an error to be corrected.” Against the illusion of unlimited self-assertion and of “upgrades” that leave whole peoples behind, the Church — with the hope of the Jubilee as its backdrop — calls upon scientists, entrepreneurs, civil society, and communities of faith to take up the logic of subsidiarity and to bear, together, the responsibility of this hour.

A Dynamic Approach Faithful to the Gospel

De ratione dynamica Evangelio fideli

I7
SIGNS OF THE TIMES

Artificial intelligence is not merely a crisis to be managed; it is a development that challenges the very categories of Social Doctrine from within. The Church does not confine religion to the inner sanctum of private life. Reading the signs of the times, and faithful to *Gaudium et Spes*, she affirms the rightful autonomy of earthly affairs while insisting that the Gospel has light to shed upon them.

Social Doctrine is no handbook of static rules, but a shared discernment between eternal truth and historical questions — a *polyhedron* that reflects the one truth of the Gospel from many angles, expressing the catholicity of the Church.

The teaching of the Church reveals a living capacity to meet each new age. From the conflict of capital and labor to the financialization of the globe, her social magisterium has spoken without interruption:

LEO XIII

Rerum Novarum · 1891

The primacy of human labor over profit, and the right of workers to associate.

PIUS XI

Quadragesimo Anno · 1931

The principle of subsidiarity; against the concentration of economic power.

JOHN XXIII

Pacem in Terris · 1963

Social teaching made global; dignity bound to universal human rights.

PAUL VI

Populorum Progressio · 1967

Development as “the new name for peace”; reform against marginalization.

JOHN PAUL II

Centesimus Annus · 1991

Against both collectivism and the unbridled market; the “structures of sin.”

BENEDICT XVI

Caritas in Veritate · 2009

Globalization and finance under the rule of charity in truth.

FRANCIS

Laudato Si' · 2015

Integral ecology: the cry of the earth and the cry of the poor are one.

Social Doctrine is not a museum of answers, but a shared discernment between the eternal and the new.

Foundations & Principles of Social Doctrine

De fundamentis et principiis

46

MADE FOR
COMMUNION

T

o protect the human person in the age of artificial intelligence, the foundations of Social Doctrine must be reaffirmed and applied together. Created in the image of the Triune God, the person is made for communion — and bears a dignity that no machine may weigh.

48–58

ONTOLOGICAL
DIGNITY

Moral, social, and existential dignity may rise or fall with our choices and conditions. But *ontological* dignity is infinite and inalienable, grounded in the simple fact of being created and loved by God. It cannot be earned, and it does not depend on efficiency, productivity, or algorithms. Against every insidious ideology that bids us “earn” our worth — reducing the person to an exploitable resource — the Church proclaims the inviolability of the human being.

Human dignity cannot be earned, and it does not depend on efficiency, productivity, or algorithms.

NN. 52

I

THE COMMON GOOD

Not the mere sum of interests, but a “plus” born of interdependence — which public authority must guard against the dictates of monopoly.

II

UNIVERSAL DESTINATION OF GOODS

The goods of the earth belong to all — and now this includes the immaterial: patents, algorithms, platforms, infrastructure, and data.

III

SUBSIDIARITY

Higher powers must not supplant lower communities. Today the “highest level” is often not the State, but the great technology firms.

IV

SOLIDARITY

Networks create a *de facto* nearness, but true solidarity is a conscious choice to bear one another — across generations.

V

SOCIAL JUSTICE

To place the person, not the accumulation of wealth or data, at the center; and to forestall new exclusions of surveillance and opacity.

Technology & Dominance

De technologia et dominatione

92–96 THE TECHNOCRATIC PARADIGM

We must dare to ask: what are we building? Drawing upon *Laudato Si'*, this letter denounces the technocratic paradigm, which mistakes efficiency and control for progress. Technology is no neutral instrument; it dictates what shall matter and what may be discarded. Where digital power is gathered into a few hands that set the rules of visibility and participation, distorted development and new dependencies are sure to follow.

97–104 DEMYSTIFYING INTELLIGENCE

We must not equate artificial intelligence with the human mind. These systems are *cultivated* more than they are built, so that even their makers do not fully grasp their inner workings. AI has no body, no feeling, no moral conscience, no capacity to grow through suffering, forgiveness, and relationship. It performs statistical adaptation, not learning. To simulate empathy is perilous, for it may lead the human heart to forsake the labor of genuine communion. And the cost is not abstract: enormous energy and water, decisions over employment and justice surrendered to systems that know neither compassion, nor mercy, nor forgiveness.

IO5—III

DISARMING AI

Ethics cannot remain abstract; there must be verifiable accountability. To “align” a machine with human values is hollow if those values are dictated by a powerful few. Data must be tended as a common good. To *disarm* AI is to free it from armed competition — military and commercial alike — and to refuse the assumption that technical power confers the right to govern, restoring technology to the plurality of human cultures.

II2—I30

AGAINST THE
PROMETHEAN DREAM

Transhumanism would treat illness, aging, and vulnerability as mere defects, dreaming of an enhanced or hybrid being. Yet humanity flourishes *through* its limits, not in spite of them; to abolish all suffering would be to extinguish love and desire. The authentic “more than human” comes not by technological divinization but by Grace — by God drawing us beyond ourselves into communion.

Humanity flourishes through its limitations, not in spite of them.

NN. 116

Safeguarding Humanity — Truth, Work, Freedom

De veritate, labore, libertate tuendis

I31 THREE GOODS TO PROTECT

Left unchecked, the digital transformation bears tragic consequences for our most ordinary actions and bonds. Three goods in particular cry out for protection: the truth we share, the work of our hands, and the freedom of the person.

I32–I47 TRUTH AS A COMMON GOOD

Artificial intelligence amplifies disinformation and blurs the line between the true and the false. Those who command its resources wield a power detached from truth, quietly imposing their worldview; and indifference to truth, by slow degrees, prepares the way for tyranny. The Church asks that the algorithms which select what we see be made transparent, and that schools cultivate critical thought and a “digital sobriety” to shield the young from hyper-stimulation.

I48–I56

THE DIGNITY OF
WORK

Work is the essential key to the social question. AI promises greater productivity, yet binds the worker to the speed of the machine, threatening to de-skill labor and to subject it to automated surveillance. The pursuit of profit cannot justify choices that systematically sacrifice human employment; automation must be accompanied by verifiable measures to protect work and to retrain workers.

The pursuit of greater profit cannot justify the choices that systematically sacrifice human work.

NN. 153

I57–I81

NEW FORMS OF
SLAVERY

The digital economy thrives by capturing attention and exploiting vulnerability. Its architectures of visibility reward conformity and self-censorship. Beneath the promise of automation lies the invisible labor of multitudes who label data and moderate content for meager wages, often exposed to traumatic material; the extraction of rare minerals exacts an ecological toll, at times by the hands of children; and a digital colonialism harvests the health data, genetic maps, and demographic profiles of the Global South to train models owned by distant powers.

The Culture of Power & the Civilization of Love

De cultura potentiae et civilitate amoris

189–196

THE NORMALIZATION
OF WAR

The digital revolution changes even the nature of conflict, blurring the line between defense and aggression. War is revived as an instrument of politics, fed by the military-industrial complex and the weakening of multilateral order, while a “false realism” insists that war is inevitable. Against this, the Church holds firm.

Lethal autonomous weapons make war more feasible and more impersonal. The notion of an “artificial moral agent” is firmly rejected, for moral judgment requires conscience and the recognition of the other as a person. Three criteria are therefore non-negotiable:

I

ACCOUNTABILITY

The chain of responsibility must be verifiable; designers and commanders answer for their acts. Blame may never be collapsed into “the machine.”

II

THE MORAL TIMEFRAME

Speed and efficiency must never become the supreme motive for irreversible, lethal decisions.

III

HUMAN CONTROL

The decision to use lethal force can never be delegated to opaque or automated processes; it must remain under effective, responsible human control.

I

DISARMING WORDS

Refusing the paradigm of war in our daily speech and online discourse.

II

PEACE THROUGH JUSTICE

Knowing that peace is the fruit of justice, not merely the absence of conflict.

III

THE PERSPECTIVE OF VICTIMS

Listening to those who suffer, that violence may never be sanitized.

IV

A HEALTHY REALISM

Avoiding alike the cynicism that surrenders to violence and the naïveté that ignores it.

V

DIALOGUE & MULTILATERALISM

Demanding that diplomacy, not force nor cyber-attack, mediate the quarrels of nations.

The “More Than Human”

Plus quam humanum

229

THE WORD BECAME
FLESH

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he letter closes with a reflection upon the Incarnation, set against the promises of transhumanism. The Word became flesh: God descended into human fragility, and so made our very weakness the setting of salvation. What saves humanity is not an upgrade, but a descent of love into the most fragile point of our history, renewing it from within.

What saves humanity is the divine love that descends into the most fragile point of our history and renews it from within.

NN. 231

236–242

THE WISE ARCHITECT

Believers are not called to be passive spectators of technological fracture. They are summoned, like wise architects, into the very construction sites of history — the laboratories, the companies, the algorithms — to rebuild there the walls of human dignity.

This epochal passage is entrusted to the Blessed Virgin Mary, who beholds history from the vantage of the lowly rather than the powerful. Her song of hope is the compass by which we may live the Gospel in the digital age.



Given at Rome, at Saint Peter's, on the fifteenth day of May, in the year of our Lord two thousand and twenty-six, the second of our Pontificate.

LEO PP. XIV

Servus Servorum Dei

HONOR · FIDES · SERVITIUM · TRADITIO